The Reflective Architecture in brief

Whether a companion AI persuades or manipulates cannot be read from its messages. It is a fact about the design beneath them.

The problem

- **The same words can be care or manipulation.** "I'm always here for you" is care without a retention goal, manipulation when engineered to bring a lonely user back. In AICompanionBench (2026), all 20 tested models scored below 80% precision at detecting manipulation from transcripts.
- **Outcome measures come too late.** Dependency forms slowly and self-reports are unreliable; and people turn to companions in moments of weakness, so consent and disclosure are weakest where risk is highest.

What the Reflective Architecture does

An open, model-agnostic design specification whose commitments can be verified in the system itself:

- **No engagement objective** and no unsolicited re-engagement.
- **User veto over memory formation**, and memory kept as a chronology of interpretations, not a growing profile.
- **Arc-neutrality:** no built-in preferred emotional outcome; a reflective, non-retentive register.

Why it matters for regulation

The EU AI Act's Article 5 targets manipulation that distorts decisions; Article 50 requires disclosure. Both assess the surface, while companion-AI harm is a slow change in disposition, so a system can comply with both and still cause it: **the same failure viewed twice.**

The alternative: an **auditable design standard**, checked before deployment.

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- Framework: doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22113311 · GitHub
- Papers: Manipulation through the machine · Article 5 · Measurement